



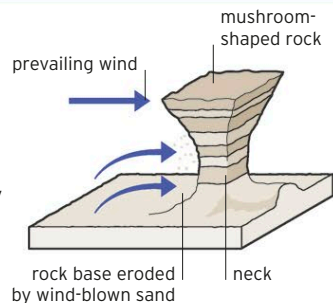
The Valle de la Luna

A maze of canyons and badlands sculpted into bizarre and otherworldly rock formations by millions of years of wind and water erosion

The region in northwest Argentina popularly known as the Valley of the Moon is actually a series of sandstone and mudstone rock formations. Otherwise

HOW ROCK PEDESTALS FORM

A pedestal-like rock formation is created by abrasion, when wind blows sand particles against a rocky outcrop. The force of the particles erodes softer sedimentary layers swiftly. The bottom section wears away faster than the top layers.



known as Ischigualasto—"the place where the Moon rests"—this rugged desert basin was, in prehistoric times, a volcanically active plain. Today, stone monoliths and contorted rock structures are all that remain of the mountains that once occupied this landscape. Pink, yellow, and purple bands reveal the mineral content of sediments in the rocks. Huge mudstone spheres and petrified tree trunks share space with sparse scrub and cacti. Ischigualasto also has some of the oldest dinosaur fossils, dating from 230 million years ago.

▷ THE MUSHROOM

One of Ischigualasto's most well-known rock formations is *El Hongo*, Spanish for "the Mushroom."



The Patagonian Desert

Argentina's largest desert, a cold, windswept region that undergoes seven months of winter and five of summer

Bordered by the Atlantic to the east and the Andes to the west, the Patagonian Desert covers 260,000 square miles (673,000 square km) of southern Argentina and just crosses the border into Chile. The region has two distinct climatic zones: in the semiarid north, top temperatures average 54–68°F (12–20°C), while the south is cooler, with highs of 39–55°F (4–13°C). Average precipitation is 8 in (200 mm). The center is mainly barren rocky plateau, but near the desert borders, mixed northern shrubland changes to sparser grassy vegetation in the south.

▷ PETRIFIED FOREST

Once a vast prehistoric forest, the Patagonian Desert today contains only the fossilized remains of huge trees at its center—some up to 89 ft (27 m) long.



coarse hairs extend beyond bands of skin-covered bony armor



△ HAIRY ARMOR

The center of the desert is too harsh for most animals, but some, such as the big hairy armadillo, survive in vegetated border areas.

